

Deep Dive: Finding a Mentor

Sue Nokes

You talked to me about mentors and the importance of mentors. I think it is very important to have somebody that you can trust, that you admire and respect, that will give you the honest opinion and assessment of your performance.

I've seen a couple of things happen. First of all, we often will ask someone to be our mentor because of their position within the organization that you're a part of, whether that's for profit in academia or in business.

And often it's not a good choice, and the reason it's not a good choice is because they don't see you perform every day. So, I was always getting asked if I would be somebody's mentor. And it isn't that you don't want to, it's a matter of, "I really can't help you if I'm not in the meetings with you, and I can't see how you interact with others or if I'm not around when you're leading your people."

So, finding a mentor who can truly assess your performance and sees you in your day-to-day operations is important. Number one. Number two. Finding somebody that will tell you when your baby's ugly. So, as you're thinking about your career. Remember, it is *yours*. You own it. 80/20 proposition. 80 percent is your responsibility to grow and develop your skills and deliver goods so that the organization provides an environment that's conducive for your growth and development.

But don't look for people that are like you. Know yourself. Take an inventory. But understand what your gifts are and what your specialties are. And then look for mentors or people that you can grow and learn from that cover what I would call your deficits or flat sides of your tire so that they're not necessarily who you want to hang out with and then you want to go on vacation with, but they are someone that has a skill or a talent that you need to learn and develop from.

So that's who you surround yourself with. Don't be intimidated by folks that are smarter than you. Learn from them. Surround yourself with excellent talent.